

INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 18~10~2025
-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"

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Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts

All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or
indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.

There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of
other topics in the main exam.

INDIAN NEGOTIATORS IN WASHINGTON

Backchannels, firm line,
oil prices behind return
to India-US talks table

**AANCHAL MAGAZINE
& ANIL SASI**
NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 17

EXPLAINED

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WITH INDIAN negotiators back in Washington this week for a renewed push to seal the India-US trade deal, there are at least three factors that seem relevant to these fresh deliberations.

One, “backchannel” talks, as part of the diplomatic spadework,

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BUSINESS AS USUAL

By UNNY



Curb on use of ‘ORS’
term brings to light a
doctor’s 8-year battle

ANONNA DUTT
NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 17

ADIABETIC child from Chennai is rushed to the ICU, severely dehydrated. His parents had done everything right — or so they

thought. They had given him a tetra-pack “ORS” drink after he began vomiting and passing loose stools. By the time he reached the hospital, his condition had spiraled into an emergency.

In another part of the country,

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FROM PAGE ONE

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● Behind return to Indo-US talks table

are learnt to have continued even when trade relations deteriorated. Moreover, on the defence and strategic dialogue, sources said, it has been “very good business as usual.” This is one key reason why strategic ties are on track even if trade talks sputter or face hurdles. New Delhi’s expectation is that if all goes well with the trade negotiations, India could see the two sets of US tariffs, adding up to 50 per cent, being replaced by a “much lower” number.

Two, the Indian position has been adequately clarified to the Americans that there are certain things which India will not yield on, even if there is a cost to pay for it and that New Delhi is willing to bear some pain on certain issues of principles, a government official said.

And that India’s stance of passive resistance, while not being an aggressive stance like that adopted by China, is ostensibly working. New Delhi’s view is that it will not compromise on its strategic autonomy and will not be dictated to by anyone on whom it should be doing business with, particularly when it comes to Russia, a key and time-tested strategic partner.

Three, while the economic advantages are less compelling now to pick up Russian crude now when prices are hovering around \$65 a barrel, as compared to nearly double these rates when India started buying Russian oil, there is a tapering that has already commenced.

It is the private companies such as Reliance Industries and Rosneft-owned Nayara Energy that are picking up Russian oil, and the US side is learnt to have initiated separate talks with Indian private refiners on this. President Donald Trump’s statement Wednesday did nuance the warning this time over the tapering of Russian oil, saying this is “a process” and indicating it could take time.

The problem in completely stopping Russian crude buy, despite it not being a compelling issue now from an economic standpoint, is that this is seen in New Delhi as a sovereign decision where no external party should be dictating, or seen to be dictating, the terms of such engagement.

The bigger issue is what comes next after Russian oil. “Tomorrow, we could be told not to buy S-400 (mobile surface-to-air missile) systems from Russia and only buy equipment from the US, never mind the fact that it comes in with end-use restrictions. If one were to yield on oil, there could be more such demands,” the official said.

“Whatever said and done, the Russians have kept supplying us with arms and ammunition... They have not really failed us ever since the 1970s. That has to be a consideration for us in what is a long relationship with many facets to it,” the official said.

“At the time that India started buying Russian oil, it was an absolute necessity. We actually, in a way, made things easier for the whole world by taking Russian oil when prices were well above \$100 plus (per barrel). Today, the market is much more settled. At \$65, if you withdraw (from buying Russian oil), prices will go up, but they are not going to be in that (\$100 plus) range. So the sit-

uation is commercially different,” the official said.

Trump claimed that Prime Minister Narendra Modi assured him that India would stop buying Russian oil and cited a conversation Wednesday. The Ministry of External Affairs Thursday denied knowledge of any such conversation and reiterated its stated position on the Russian purchase for which the US had slapped an extra 25 per cent tariff penalty in August.

Trump’s public posturing makes it all the more difficult for India to cut back on Russian oil immediately even if it wanted to. Oil, Russia’s biggest source of revenue, is a lever that the Trump administration believes it can use to force the Kremlin’s hand into ending the Ukraine war. New Delhi is the second-largest buyer of its oil after Beijing, and is in the midst of renewed trade pact negotiations with Washington.

Also, even as Indian negotiators are in Washington this week, officials said shared concerns over critical minerals due to China’s curbs could provide the much-needed political push for the India-US trade deal that has remained stalled for months.

In an interview Tuesday, US Secretary of the Treasury Scott Bessent framed China’s new export controls on critical minerals as “China versus the rest of the world”, stating that the US is pushing back firmly and expects strong support from “Europe, India and other Asian democracies”.

Bessent’s remarks could signal an underlying US strategy to ring-fence Chinese trade dominance with the help of its allies, and indicate that despite recent trade tensions with India, Washington still regards New Delhi as a strategic and economic partner – a stance underscored by the renewed escalation of the trade war with China.

“It is undeniable that China’s aggressive stance (on trade, and issues such as critical minerals) could work to India’s advantage,” the official said.

While high tariffs on Indian products have begun to hurt Indian MSMEs (micro, small and medium enterprises), the White House has also faced sharp criticism for pushing India towards the China camp.

Modi’s recent phone call with Trump, along with the visit by newly appointed US Ambassador-designate Sergio Goro, who met the Prime Minister, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal over the weekend, has also built fresh momentum for a long-awaited agreement. India has signalled its willingness to step up energy imports from the US to address the additional tariffs for imports of Russian oil.

On the trade deal too, while an apparent tussle within the Trump administration between the hardliners that include Peter Navarro and others such as Scott Bessent derailed the India deal the first time around, the Indian side too is believed to have contributed to the issues by delays at its end too. “By undoing Deng Xiaoping’s ‘hide your strength, bide your time’ tenet, the present dispensation in China is doing itself some harm. And that could end up helping our case,” the official said.

● Curb on use of ‘ORS’ term brings to light a doctor’s 8-year battle

a young girl recovering from burn injuries suddenly becomes critical because of dehydration. Her caregivers, too, had been faithfully administering a store-bought “ORS” product.

The common thread in both stories? Packaged, flavoured drinks that claimed to be “ORS solutions”.

For years, Hyderabad-based paediatrician Dr Sivaranjini Santhosh has been collecting stories like these — heartbreaking accounts from parents, colleagues and anxious relatives who reach out to her through her social media platforms. Her aim has been to ensure that children with diarrhoea do not end up consuming flavoured, sweetened beverages in place of the genuine Oral Rehydration Solution (ORS), a landmark discovery in medicine pioneered by Dr Dilip Mahalanabis.

On Wednesday, the country’s food regulator issued an order banning all beverages from using the term ORS in their trade-marked name, withdrawing an earlier order allowing the term with disclaimers.

Over the last decade or so, several tetra-pack products claiming to be ORS have entered the market without actually adhering to the sugar and salt ratios needed for a person to effectively absorb the water they are drinking, Dr Santhosh told The Indian Express.



Hyderabad paediatrician Dr Sivaranjini Santhosh

Her journey started with educating people on social media around eight years ago — she saw children coming to her clinics who were severely dehydrated despite being given what the parents assumed was an ORS solution.

But she knew that was not enough. These products were not only giving children excess sugar, they were actively harming their health. “Even if a product carries the warning ‘not ORS’ — which many of the new products do not — people still think that it is an ORS solution because that’s what the brand name suggests. It misleads people into choosing products that can actually worsen the diarrhoea in children and may even lead to deaths if timely med-

ical intervention does not happen,” said Dr Santhosh.

“ORS is a medical product that has saved millions of lives. Around 13% of the deaths in children under the age of five years happen because of diarrhoea and ORS is an effective tool for preventing these deaths. There is a fixed formula for how much glucose, sodium chloride, and potassium chloride has to be there in the ORS solution. This formula is such that the sugar and salt actually pull water with them into the body and rehydrate a person. Any excess sugar will actually pull the water back into the gut and worsen the diarrhoea,” she explained.

In her eight-year long journey to ensure that people are not misled, she went to the Telangana High Court, wrote to the health minister and the prime minister. “I knew I had to stop this when I saw severely dehydrated children coming into my clinics, when my colleagues reported that children ended up in ICUs because they were given these tetra-pack solutions that did not really help.”

But there were several ups and downs. At first, she did not even know who she should reach out to. “Being a medical product, I assumed that the drug regulator (Central Drugs and Standards Control Organisation) would regulate these products. When they wrote back to me, I was surprised to find out that it

was actually the food regulator.”

Dr Santhosh also wrote to medical associations to discontinue sponsorships from these products. “I was isolated, people would talk behind my back. Even my family at times thought whether it was worth it — these were big companies that I was taking on.” At one point, she considered giving up, but kept going.

Then came an April 2022 order where the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) restricted the use of the term ORS, but the relief did not last long. “Within months, there was another order that said that the companies could continue to use ORS in their names as long as they carried a warning stating that it was not an ORS solution. Even that order they did not implement properly. Newer products entered the market that did not carry the warning either,” said Dr Santhosh.

Her struggle came to fore earlier this month when she posted a video about the deaths of children in Madhya Pradesh after consuming tainted syrup. She asked a simple question — how could doctors alone ensure the safety of children when regulators kept allowing harmful products to enter the market.

And, finally, the FSSAI on Wednesday banned the use of ‘ORS’ in these beverage names.

“We have won,” said Dr Santhosh.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi meets Sri Lankan Prime Minister Harini Amarasuriya during her official visit to India, in New Delhi, Friday. *PTI*

Education, empowerment of women figure in talks between Modi & Lanka PM

Amarasuriya visits IIT Delhi, discusses collaboration

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 17

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi on Friday met visiting Sri Lanka Prime Minister Harini Amarasuriya, and discussed education, women's empowerment, innovation, development cooperation and welfare of fishermen. Amarasuriya is on a three-day visit to India beginning Thursday, her first trip to the country after assuming office. "Our discussions covered a broad range of areas, including education, women's empowerment, innovation, development cooperation and welfare of our fishermen," Modi said on X, after the meeting. "As close neighbours, our cooperation holds immense importance for the prosperity of our two peoples as well as the shared region," he said.

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said Modi conveyed that Amarasuriya's visit would impart fresh momentum to the "historic and multifaceted India-Sri Lanka ties". It said the two leaders discussed measures to strengthen cooperation in a number of areas, including education, technology, innovation development cooperation and welfare of Indian fishermen. Highlighting the special ties between India and Sri Lanka, Modi reaffirmed India's commitment to work together in the shared development journey of the two countries, it said. Modi also recalled his State visit to Sri Lanka in April during which he held fruitful discussions with President Anura Kumara Disanayaka. Modi conveyed his warm wishes to President Disanayaka, and said that he looked forward

to their continued engagements, according to the MEA. The Sri Lankan PM also visited IIT Delhi on Friday and discussed joint efforts for the creation of an academic and research hub at the institute. "IIT Delhi is a prestigious engineering and research institute in our neighbourhood. I believe there is significant potential for academic and research collaboration between our institutes and IIT Delhi. We are already collaborating with IIT Madras, and we look forward to exploring the ways in which our institutions can collaborate with IIT Delhi as well," said Amarasuriya. She also visited the CM SHRI school in Rohini, accompanied by Delhi Education Minister Ashish Sood. The visit aimed to showcase the capital's modern school infrastructure, innovative teaching methods and digital learning environment.

India Post to deliver mails and parcels with timeline guarantees

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 17

UNION COMMUNICATIONS Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia on Friday said India Post will roll out a guarantee-based service of mails and parcels with delivery timelines of 24 hours and 48 hours. The minister said that 24 hours and 48 hours mail delivery and next-day parcel delivery will start from January onwards. "We are going to launch new products with guaranteed delivery of mails and parcels. There will be 24-hour Speed Post service which will ensure delivery of mails within 24 hours. Similarly, there will be a 48-hour Speed Post," Scindia said. These services will be launched in January, he added. He said

that there will be similar services for next-day delivery of parcels which will ensure that the parcel gets delivered the next day from around 3-5 days at present. He said that the Department of Posts will also launch products for enhancing international postal service through tracked international, speed post international and direct line. The tracked international service and direct line will be launched in January and speed post international will be launched in March. The minister said that the government aims to transform India Post from a "cost centre" to a "profit centre" by 2029.



THE EDITORIAL PAGE

The gift of Athena



PRATAP BHANU MEHTA

Work of Nobel Laureate Joel Mokyr shines a light on path India must take to become a knowledge power

WHEN I WAS appointed to the National Knowledge Commission in 2005, a colleague recommended that I read 2025 Nobel Laureate Joel Mokyr's book, *The Gifts of Athena*, to gain a broad understanding of how knowledge economies are produced. Mokyr is known as the non-economist's economist — not just because he uses economic theory in elegant and accessible prose rather than impenetrable math, but also because he resists a deeper economic reductionism that might be summed up as: "It's the incentives, stupid." Nothing has corrupted our thinking about development more than the language of incentives (which, of course, matter) colonising our ways of thinking about the social world.

For Mokyr, knowledge is not simply a tap that can be turned on by getting the incentives right — as if increasing demand or payments will automatically generate a response. Knowledge is not just another input where greater demand produces higher supply. In another book, *The Lever of Riches*, he put it dramatically: Necessity is not the mother of invention; one must also account for the capacity to respond to necessity. Knowledge economies are more difficult creations — more mysterious and more wondrous.

Another striking feature of Mokyr's work is his Weberian sensibility about historical causation. Social reality is causal but not law-like. Although his books have overarching arguments, they are attentive to complexity and to the conjunctures that make an argument work. In this sense, his work is much richer, and his histories more rewarding, than those of other historically-minded economists who have won the Nobel Prize, such as Douglas North or Daron Acemoglu and James A Robinson. Their emphasis on institutions is salutary, but their account of institutional causality is ultimately too abstract and rests on a more simplistic and tendentious reading of history. Mokyr offers a genuinely historical and sociological critique of economics' dominant modes of thinking. He uses parsimony when appropriate, not as an end in itself. His history, like all serious history, will be controversial in parts, but never simple-minded. In *The Lever of Riches*, he is attentive to the conditions under which his explanations may not hold. One of the remarkable things about his histories is how much they make you think.

Mokyr's account is Weberian in another way: It makes space for the explanatory power

of ideas. But it is also a conjunctural account that links two forms of knowledge: Propositional knowledge, which concerns regularities in nature, and prescriptive knowledge, which is about techniques — how to make things work. The friend who recommended *The Gifts of Athena* thought its central argument especially relevant to the Indian context. Many societies have been good at discovery. But for Mokyr, the Industrial Revolution cannot be explained by factors like the comparative price of energy or heroic individual inventions. It was sustained by the interaction between propositional and prescriptive knowledge — between discovery and invention. The subtext for India was clear: Science and engineering need to be integrated into a productive feedback loop. This has been a structural weakness of the Indian knowledge system. The 20th century, Mokyr suggested, saw the deepest institutionalisation of the relationship between these two knowledge forms. But it remains controversial what actually enables such institutionalisation.

Mokyr's histories are somewhat sceptical of the state. Not only is the state bad at picking winners, it often prevents even known winners from realising their potential — as in China's past. Historically, and sometimes against the grain of his own narrative, Mokyr tends to downplay the role of the state in creating the preconditions for sustained innovation. Yet contemporary China now offers a living refutation of his thesis on the state, even as it vindicates his account of the feedback loops between different forms of knowledge.

The fascination of Mokyr's work lies in its claim about a shift in elite cultures. The explosion of interest in scientific knowledge among European elites in the early modern period was astounding. It is important to remember that this scientific temperament does not exist primarily at the individual level — many great scientists believed all sorts of weird things — but is embedded in the epistemic cultures of institutions. Mokyr does not reduce science to sociology, as sociologists of science often do; science has its own autonomy as a mode of human experience and as a causal force. What he conveys is how an elite culture forms around science: Institutions, networks of diffusion, and most remarkably, social conditions that spot talent and allow it to flourish. His account of the political dynamics of this shift in A

Culture of Growth: The Origins of the Modern Economy is interesting, if a little tendentious. It rests on the claim that a paradoxical combination produced Europe's intellectual dynamism: Political fragmentation combined with a trans-European republic of letters. States competed for talent, but within a culture that allowed ideas to circulate freely across borders.

But why was European fragmentation different from that elsewhere? Consider post-imperial fragmentation in other regions, including India. New intellectual histories of India make one wonder if something else is at work. One of the remarkable features of Indian intellectual history is how successfully it created a trans-political and open republic of letters. Not only were religious and literary texts widely disseminated, but a small town like Navadipa could become the epicentre of Navya-Nyaya logic in the 17th century — surpassing even Benares. Nyaya manuscripts became pan-Indian currency, despite political fragmentation. So India, too, had political pluralism and extensive elite circulation. Comparative literacy rates in 17th to 19th-century England and India are contested, at least if Dharampal is to be believed. The sad truth is that Indian economic, intellectual, and cultural history still has too many large gaps for the Indian case to be fully diagnosed. The few references to India his work are comparatively flat, largely owing to the paucity of sources.

Mokyr forces us to confront a profound truth: Knowledge does not grow on its own. It is cultivated by cultures and institutions and legitimised by ideas. If India is serious about becoming a knowledge power, it must confront the structural disconnects in its own knowledge systems — the weak bridges between science and engineering, discovery and application, the factory and lab. It must learn to reward and match talent. The real challenge is not just investment or incentives, which we are throwing around freely. We will get easily dazzled by an odd win, ISRO or a new AI centre. The real challenge is building a sustained culture of innovation. Athena, or in the Indian context Saraswati, are not just goddesses to be worshipped: They have to become palpable social forces.

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AI IN PLAY

Google's \$15 billion investment for hub in Andhra Pradesh is a big boost to India's plans in this sector

THE LAST FEW years have seen a dramatic surge in AI investments, driven by global tech majors such as Microsoft, Alphabet, Meta, Nvidia and OpenAI. As developing AI models and then making them available for use at a global level requires huge capital, the scale of the investments being made has reached impressive proportions. In 2024, global corporate investment in AI touched \$252.3 billion as per the AI index report from Stanford University. As per McKinsey, the data centres needed to handle AI processing are expected to require \$5.2 trillion in capex by 2030, the bulk of which is likely to be directed towards technology developers to produce chips and computing hardware. While some have expressed concerns over this AI boom — the IMF has, for instance, warned that "the risk is also that lofty profit expectations will ultimately be unmet" — others are more optimistic with tech majors stepping up their investments.

Earlier this week, Google announced that it will invest \$15 billion over the next five years (2026-2030) to set up an AI data centre in Andhra Pradesh. Situated in Visakhapatnam, it will be Google's largest outside the US, and will include a "purpose-built data centre campus capable of gigawatt-scale compute capacity". Earlier this year, during its second quarter earnings season, the company had raised its capex forecast for the year to \$85 billion to meet the growing demand as adoption rates for both firms and companies surge. This is a big boost to India's plans to be a major player in this space. India's data centre industry had crossed the 1 GW mark in 2024 as per a report by JLL. Estimated to account for 52 per cent of the country's capacity, Mumbai leads the market, followed by Chennai and Delhi.

The world over, governments are announcing ambitious plans and pledging huge resources in the AI space. The Indian government has also taken several steps to help build the larger ecosystem in the country. Ten semiconductor manufacturing projects, including high-volume fabs and OSATs (outsourced semiconductor assembly and test), have been approved. Alongside, 23 chip-design projects have been sanctioned by the government and 12 startups have been chosen to build indigenous large language models and small language models. Thus, across the spectrum, from the physical infrastructure (data centres) and the semiconductor projects (chips) to developing large language models, India is making progress. These efforts need to be supplemented by a similar focus on boosting research and development and skilling the labour force.



SUMANA ROY

HOW DO WE console the dead? For those who have outlived the departed, there are codes — rituals. A holding of hand, a touch on the shoulder, the grace of an embrace, flowers in one culture, a stock of provisions in another and prayers. But how do we console the dead, the one just gone? The sudden disappearance of life, of breath and sap, from what was alive just a little while ago, feels like an irreversible theft. Nothing one does, no legislation, no inquiry, can undo this stealing. In a Louise Glück poem, the speaker, a bereaved child, writes this to the dead father: "*From time to time, I run my hand over your face/ lightly, like a dustcloth*". A dustcloth — how easily dust settles on those who cannot move, furniture and the dead. Dustcloth — how delicate death is. "*Against your cheek, my hand is warm/ and full of tenderness*." This is how the poem ends, recording the difference in temperature between life and death, a generically mammalian interpretation.

How do we console the killed, those forced out of life? Death, untimely, an accident, unnatural, turns the familiar foreign. The language for consoling the foreign is unknown to us. What happens when the murdered is of a different species? Our emotional conditioning allows us rituals of remembrance, memorialising and consolation for those of our own species. Similar feelings for other species seem like an indulgence, an unnecessary eighth note. It is as if consolation,

WHEN A TREE DIES

Sometimes grief does not recognise boundaries between species

too, must have its own genres.

One doesn't know how to console someone who's lost a plant. To import the words one uses for the loss of a human would feel like parody, perhaps even sarcasm. There are no rituals — no abstention or withdrawal, no time cycles of purification. There is no officially sanctioned leave, no paperwork. This affection and attachment for a different species is meant to exist on the margins, like trees are in architectural design, pushed near boundary walls as if in an instructive analogy about where our emotions for other species are meant to be.

More than a millennium ago, Deola Bai's name might have been a peripheral character in the Jataka Tales. But here she was — her age and her action — part of the news cycle. What had this 85-year-old woman done? Nothing criminal. But she had been captured on camera crying inconsolably. The peepal sapling that she had planted about 20 years ago and cared for "like her own child" — as someone in Sara Gondi, her village in Chhattisgarh's Khairagarh district said — had been cut "for profit".

I haven't been able to understand why a sight like that should generate such extremities of responses, between being moved and being bemused. I would imagine that most of us have felt like this at various points in our lives. Whether it was the calamitous felling of thousands of trees for the Siliguri SAARC highway in my hometown or something more

personal, like returning home to find a plant that will never respond to air, water and light again, I have found myself breaking down into tears. Inevitably, there's been someone in the vicinity who's spouted proof of being a human being: "It's only a tree."

Deola Bai "hugging" the tree stump and crying is bound to remind us of the Chipko movement and, by extension, of what has been characterised as an ecofeminist move. But there's someone else I have found myself going back to — Jagadish Chandra Bose and his tendency to write about plants with feeling, an unexpected thing for a scientist. In an essay about an injured plant, he writes: "The slight reduction in sunlight was not noticeable from inside the room, but the tree sensed it and expressed its melancholy with a small response". Notice the word "melancholy" he uses for the tree. Is it because we've been conditioned to believe that plants don't have emotions that it becomes hard for many to understand how we can have feelings for them?

"It is by causing injury that we can measure the living index," Bose writes about plants in his experiments. If we were to import this to the injuries caused by the death of plants on our psyche, I suppose Deola Bai's "living index" would be higher than what it would be for many of us.

Roy, a poet and writer, is associate professor at Ashoka University. Views are personal

Before closing the US trade deal

India must guard against last-minute negotiating stratagems, protect its freedom to manoeuvre, promote national interest and autonomy



ABHIJIT DAS

THE PROSPECTS FOR an India-US trade deal appear to have brightened in recent days. Going by media reports, the negotiations may well be approaching the finish line. If the meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Donald Trump at the ASEAN Summit in Kuala Lumpur does take place during October 26-28, it would provide an opportunity to finalise the trade deal. In order to guard against last-minute negotiating stratagems of the US and protect the national interest, what should the Indian government do in the endgame?

First, both sides must agree to a written document before its contents are announced. Going by media reports, Trump, at the last minute, unilaterally changed what was agreed upon in some of the bilateral trade deals between US officials and those of the partner countries, to the disadvantage of the latter. India must ensure that it does not become another victim of a one-sided deal announcement by Trump.

Second, India must look out for the US making new demands in the final stages of the negotiation and insisting on them as a condition for closing the deal. This has been a part of the US toolkit for decades at the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade (GATT)/World Trade Organisation (WTO). Even at the risk of delaying the finalisation of the deal, Indian officials must not agree to last-minute demands without due examination and consultation with concerned ministries and other stakeholders. These should be postponed for the second part of the deal at a later stage.

Third, Trump weaponising tariffs provides an important lesson to the rest of the world: Being dependent on a few markets for exports is a recipe for becoming hostage to those countries' economic and political interests. India needs to ensure that the bilateral trade deal does not further deepen its dependence on the US market. In addition, it would be in India's long-term interest to not become complicit in the US game to isolate China by compelling countries to decouple from global value chains involving China. India needs to guard against any provision in its bilateral deal with the US that ostensibly promotes resilient supply chains but actually targets China. Further, the government must carefully study whether the bilateral deal curtails India's autonomy to decide which countries to trade with.

Fourth, in the frenzy of bargaining in the final stages of negotiations, the less powerful parties are known to abandon many of their long-held red lines. India needs to exercise extreme caution on this score. PM Modi's emphatic assertion that the interests of farmers and fishermen would be protected has certainly been reassuring. However, India's negotiators cannot afford to ignore red lines



C R Sasikumar

on issues related to the digital economy now and intellectual property in the second phase of negotiations. As the digital sector can impart significant buoyancy to India's economy, these issues merit a detailed discussion.

The following issues can be said to constitute the core of US interests in the digital economy: First, prevent India from imposing taxes on digital players headquartered in the US; Second, prevent India from leveraging its data advantage and creating domestic digital champions, including through sharing anonymised government data exclusively with Indian domestic entities; and third, prevent India from effectively regulating the digital sector.

The US can secure the above and many other objectives in the digital sector by getting India to agree to the following sentence in the trade deal: "Both countries agree to grant non-discriminatory treatment to digital services, and suppliers of these services, from the other country". India's negotiators must recognise that this would substantially compromise the prospects of the country creating a vibrant domestic digital sector. Such a provision would prohibit the government from giving a boost to domestic digital players, for example, by mandating that all its entities use the homegrown communication app Arattai, instead of other apps. It would also tie the government's hands from supporting its domestic start-ups through various policy interventions. Finally, it would effectively prevent the government from raising revenue by taxing activities in the digital sector overwhelmingly dominated by US players. Concessions on digital issues in the trade deal would render India's atmanirbhar and swadeshi objectives hollow and devoid

Trump weaponising tariffs provides an important lesson to the rest of the world: Being dependent on a few markets for exports is a recipe for becoming hostage to those countries' economic and political interests. India needs to ensure that the bilateral trade deal does not further deepen its dependence on the US market. Further, the government must carefully study whether the bilateral deal curtails India's autonomy to decide which countries to trade with.

of substance.

Before closing the trade deal, the government must make an objective assessment of how it would modify India's rights and obligations vis-à-vis the US as they existed on the day when PM Modi and President Trump announced the launch of negotiations for a bilateral trade agreement (February 13). If the recent US trade deals with Japan, EU and Vietnam are any indication, India may have to remove its most-favoured-nation tariffs on most industrial goods and some agricultural products, as well as provide concessions in other areas, while the US may only lower the 50 per cent tariff on Indian exports to about 15-20 per cent.

Given the asymmetry in political and economic clout between the US and India, the odds are stacked against the latter in the ongoing bilateral negotiations. Further, with India adopting a non-confrontational approach, its negotiators have been left with few chips in their pockets to bargain for reduction or elimination of the US tariffs. In light of these constraints, it would be a major achievement if India's negotiators manage to secure a mutually beneficial bilateral trade agreement with the US. If the assessment is that the outcome is skewed against India's interests, the government must not hesitate to walk away from the negotiating table. In this context, it is relevant to recall Chanakya's wisdom — when benefits accruing to kings under a treaty are to be distributed unfairly, war is preferable.

Das is a former trade negotiator and the author of the recently published book Strategies in GATT and WTO Negotiations. Views are personal

Red carpet, red flag

Signals sent by Taliban Minister Muttaqi's visit to Deoband have disappointed many in the country



FAIZAN MUSTAFA

TO LAY CLAIM to the title of "vishwaguru", India must assume ethical leadership of the world. As a founder-member of the United Nations and original signatory to the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, it must demonstrate an unequivocal commitment to human rights and gender justice. Our opposition to terrorism, too, is an article of faith. The current geopolitical scenario may have necessitated a warm welcome for the Taliban's visiting foreign minister, Amir Muttaqi. Yet, is it not a fact that Muttaqi has been declared a terrorist by the UN? Diplomacy sometimes demands such compromises. But whatever the compulsions, we should have put our foot down regarding the state-arranged visit by Muttaqi to the seminary of Deoband. It has given the Taliban much-needed legitimacy and Muslim liberals are at a loss to understand the government's decision to organise the visit.

It is true that the Deoband ulema issued a fatwa of jihad against the British and opposed the flawed and communal idea of Partition, besides issuing fatwas against all kinds of terrorism and cow slaughter. Yet, the seminary established in 1866 by Muhammad Qasim Nanawtawi and Rashid Ahmad Gangohi represents, at its core, orthodox and conservative Sunni Islam.

Deoband signifies the dated ideas of one Sunni school, and its graduates dominate the Muslim Personal Law Board. It is opposed not only to the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) but also to modern progressive reforms in Muslim Personal Law. Most of its ideas on freedom of religion, blasphemy, triple divorce, hijab, etc, are not compatible with constitutional morality and norms. It continues to hold the Sharia as the highest norm of the legal system.

Under Article 26 of the Constitution, every religious denomination or any section thereof is entitled to establish and manage religious institutions of its choice. The Deoband seminary is entitled to teach any theology and have an opinion as per its theological school. But should the state be seen as facilitating such institutions?

The signals sent by Muttaqi's visit have disappointed many in the country. Freedom of religion under our Constitution includes freedom from religion as well. It also guarantees freedom within religion. But the Taliban does not guarantee this freedom to Afghan women. The worst kinds of women's rights violations are reported from Taliban-ruled Afghanistan. The Taliban is one of the most regressive and authoritarian regimes today. By the 1990s, 40 per cent of doctors in Afghanistan were women. Women also constituted 70 per cent of school teachers, 60 per cent of university professors and almost half of university students. Today, women's literacy in Afghanistan is at a meagre 14 per cent.

The Taliban's Jim Crow-like decrees have not come as a surprise. Its promises during the Doha deal of respecting human rights in general and women's rights in particular have proved to be empty words.

Women, who occupied one-fourth of parliamentary seats and 6.5 per cent of ministerial positions in 2021, have been completely excluded from the Taliban government. They can no longer go out and work in most sectors. They are forced to cover their faces and must be accompanied by a male guardian. Afghan women are denied access to amusement and public parks, and are banned from universities and colleges. Women are now forced to join madrasas.

Not only does the Taliban have no respect for the international human rights covenants, its ideology is also in violation of Islamic theology. The Arabic word for knowledge is *ilm*. This root word has been used in the Quran 854 times — 397 times as a noun, 425 times as a verb, and the remaining times as an adjective. The first words of divine revelation in the Quran asked the Prophet (PBUH) to read: "Read in the name of your Lord who has created (all that exists)" (Quran 96:1-5). Islam was a knowledge revolution. The Prophet himself had reportedly said that "seeking knowledge is obligatory on every Muslim male and female". (Al-Tirmidhi). There is not a single verse in the Quran or Hadiths that prohibits women from acquiring knowledge.

The Taliban seems to be ignorant of the history of Islamic civilisation. The Prophet's wife Ayesha was a great scholar who was consulted by people on theological matters. She is the most prominent narrator of the Hadith. In fact, it is impossible to talk of Islam without referring to her. Nafisa, a close relative of Ali, the fourth caliph, used to be consulted by the people and even scholars.

The Taliban leadership may not know that one of the earliest modern universities, the University of Al-Qarawiyyin in Fez, Morocco, was founded in 859 by Fatima al-Fihriya. In the 13th century, Raziya Sultan ruled over Delhi and built several schools. In Pakistan, Benazir Bhutto has been the Prime Minister, and Bangladesh has been ruled by Khaleda Zia and Sheikh Hasina Wajid for a large part of its history. Even in Afghanistan in 1880, Malalai demonstrated her courage and bravery in the battle of Maiwand. Habibi Sarabi was appointed as Governor of Bamiyan in 2005, and Azra Jafari became the first female mayor in Afghanistan in 2009.

If at all the foreign minister had to be taken to some Muslim institution, the Aligarh Muslim University, the greatest citadel of Muslim education, where a woman is the vice-chancellor, should have been chosen.

The Deoband administration, in an official statement, was cleverer than the organisers of the first press conference in Delhi. It stated categorically that "its policy of welcoming guests of India is allied with the foreign policy of the country and this visit was not their endorsement of Taliban's policies but mere continuation of historical, cultural and scholarly ties between Deoband and Afghanistan".

The writer is vice-chancellor of Chanakya National Law University, Patna. Views are personal



RAM RAJYA

BY RAM MADHAV

Can't rely only on government

To become a leader in deep tech, India needs private sector to step up

In recent years, Prime Minister Narendra Modi has emphasised enhancing India's preparedness in areas like artificial intelligence, semiconductors, quantum computing and green tech. The PM devoted considerable time to these issues in his Independence Day address this year. He insisted that every sector — MSMEs, education, healthcare, transport, agriculture — needs modernisation and innovation. He argued that self-reliance in technology, including deep tech, is essential for national security and strategic autonomy. He cautioned that excessive dependence on foreign technology weakens the nation.

"India must reduce dependence on foreign weapons, energy and critical technologies," he said, pointedly asking, "if we have the capability, why should India's money flow outside?". Underscoring that the future of the world is connected with semiconductors, modern technology and AI, he called on the youth to "dream big". He raised pertinent issues like — "Will we make our own EV batteries?"; "We need our own patented medicines"; and "We must become *atmanirbhar* in energy". He called on industry stakeholders and the private sector to come forward in this effort.

The Modi government has set up several missions around the deep-tech frontier — India Semiconductor Mission, National Quantum Mission, India AI Mission, Deep-tech Fund of Funds, and Anusandhan National Research Foundation. The government's effort is to achieve strategic autonomy and self-reliance in these areas and also to position India as one

of the leading deep-tech powers by 2035.

This is ambitious for any country. However, for India, it is a necessity. The new world is going to be controlled by countries with deep-tech power. The 20th century was all about capital and trade, whereas the 21st century is going to be about capital and technology. If India is to realise its dream of emerging as a global leader in the next couple of decades, besides the size of its economy, the strength and resilience of its frontier tech innovation and R&D systems will play a crucial role.

The big question is whether all this can be possible only through the government efforts or if several other stakeholders need to pitch in to augment the pace of our progress. Until now, the major burden of promoting India's deep-tech revolution has been shouldered by the government. India spends roughly 0.65 per cent of its GDP on R&D in science and technology. It is well below the spending of technologically advanced countries like China (2.4 per cent), the US (3.4 per cent), South Korea (4.9 per cent), and Japan (3.3 per cent). These figures may be deceptive as each country's GDP is different. In real terms, India spends roughly \$15 billion on R&D, while China spends more than \$600 billion and the US more than \$1 trillion.

This humongous gap in R&D spending is a major challenge for India in realising its ambition. But the challenge stems not from the government's inability to spend more but the private sector's reluctance to chip in. In most technologically advanced countries, the share

of private sector spending on R&D has been upwards of 70 per cent. It is around just 30 per cent in India. While the entire private sector spending on R&D in India remains below \$5 billion, American chip majors like NVIDIA and IBM alone spend \$13 billion and \$8 billion, respectively. Several of those companies allocate upwards of 10 per cent of their revenues to R&D, while in India, such allocations remain negligible.

Given this resource crunch, the pace of India's deep-tech R&D and innovation is slow. In areas like AI and quantum computing, the government's push is yielding good results, but it can only help the country catch up with advanced countries. What India needs to aim for is not just to follow the curve but to move ahead of it. Despite its linguistic diversity, vast literature and large amounts of data in regional languages and dialects, India has not been able to develop its own AI-based Large Language Model. Some minor efforts did succeed, but they remain inferior in scale and efficiency. While advanced countries produced commercially accessible quantum machines with more than 100 qubits and IBM announced the release of its Kookaburra quantum processor with 1,386 qubit capacity in a multi-chip configuration in 2025, India's IITs are still at an experimental stage with 25-qubit quantum computers.

The Modi government has seen major successes in the renewable energy sector. In the last 10 years, it grew significantly to reach 50 per cent of the country's total power ca-

pacity. However, the import dependence of this sector is a cause for concern. Until last year, our import dependency for solar modules stood at 80 per cent and inverters at 60 per cent. In critical minerals like lithium, cobalt and nickel, essential for the renewable energy industry, our import dependence is near 100 per cent. In the EV sector, Indian companies like Tata and Mahindra made significant advances. The PM proudly announced that the country has the potential to export those vehicles to over 100 countries. But the sector depends heavily on imports — almost 100 per cent in battery cells and 70 per cent in several other components. This dependency is largely on China. In an age of growing nationalisms impacting supply-chain resilience, this is worrying.

It is this scenario that prompted PM Modi to infuse massive government funding into indigenous R&D. His relentless campaign to encourage innovation and startups is also yielding tangible results. However, what is needed is a whole-of-nation approach. India's corporates, state governments, academic institutions and research organisations must come together to catch up with the energy, speed, vision, and, most importantly, the urgency of the PM.

If we fail, we will not become leaders but remain "also-rans" in a world fast transitioning to the Industry 5.0 era.

The writer, president, Indian Foundation, is with the BJP

India’s economy has moved from fragile 5 to top 5 in the world: PM

‘Country will be free of Naxalism soon, over 300 have surrendered in 75 hrs’



PM Narendra Modi at the NDTV summit on Friday. PTI

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 17

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi said on Friday that India has become unstoppable with its economy transitioning from being among the ‘Fragile five’ to ‘top five’ in the world.

He also said it is his guarantee that the day is not far when the nation would be free of Maoist terror, pointing to more and more Maoists shunning the gun and joining the mainstream.

Speaking at the NDTV World Summit at Bharat Mandapam, the PM said it was but natural to talk about an “unstoppable India” at a time when the world today faces various roadblocks and speed-breakers. “We will neither pause nor slow down; 140 crore Indians will move forward together with full momentum,” he said.

The PM said India’s inflation was below 2% while its growth rate was over 7%, while flagging tech giant Google’s announcement of \$15 billion investment in the AI sector and trade with G7 nations surging by 60%. “Today, from chips to ships, India is self-reliant and confident in every

sphere... India’s growth is shaping global opportunities,” he said.

The PM said Maoist terror was a significant issue. He hit out at the previous Congress regime for nurturing “urban Naxals” and turning a blind eye to the violence unleashed by them. “The urban Naxal ecosystem which dates back to Congress rule... they were so overpowering... that censorship would keep any incident of Maoist terror from reaching the people,” he said.

The country used to engage in debates around terrorism, Article 370, but the urban Naxals who had taken over significant institutions used to keep the nation in the dark about Maoist terrorism, the PM said.

Those who place the Constitution on their foreheads today, the PM said, are the same people who worked day and night to ensure the safety of the Maoist terrorists who didn’t believe in the very Constitution. “Governments used to be elected but those would not be recognised in the Red Corridor,” he said.

The PM said that the country would be free of Naxalism soon and that over 300 Naxals have surrendered in 75 hours.

Egypt minister calls for making Gaza peace agreement a success, meets PM

SHUBHAJIT ROY NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 17

CALLING THE Gaza peace plan as the “only game in town”, Egypt’s Foreign Minister Badr Abdelatty said on Friday that Egypt will work with the US and other regional and international partners to secure a UN Security Council resolution to establish an international stabilisation force to monitor the implementation of the Gaza peace agreement.

Speaking to journalists in Delhi on Friday, Abdelatty, who also met Prime Minister Narendra Modi, called for more Indian investments in Egypt. He also pitched Egypt at the heart of the connectivity projects, saying his country’s loss due to the disruption in the maritime traffic on the Red Sea is exceeding \$9 billion.

Abdelatty had met External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar on Thursday. On the Gaza peace plan, he said, “With regard to Gaza, we have agreed on the Trump peace plan. This is the only game in town now, and we should work on making this plan successful... Israel has its own responsibilities, and Hamas has its own responsibilities.”

He said they are in the final stages of implementing Phase 1 of the peace agreement regarding the release of hostages. “We are still waiting for the handover of remains... It’s not because Hamas is not honouring its commitments, but because of logistical problems. You cannot imagine the magnitude of destruction.”

The next step, he said, “is to go to New York to the UN Security Council in order to prepare a draft resolution which will, of course,



External Affairs Minister Jaishankar meets Egypt Foreign Minister Abdelatty in New Delhi Thursday. ANI

give legitimacy to the International Stabilisation Force. This force is extremely important in terms of monitoring the implementation...”

On connectivity, he said, “Egypt is at the heart of any connectivity projects, in light of our strategic location, in light of the Special Economic Zone in the Suez Canal... and we are open for joining any projects of connectivity.”

The minister said he encouraged more Indian companies to come to invest in the region. “We have a special industrial zone for China, and for Russia, and we are encouraging the Indian companies to have an Indian industrial zone alongside the Suez Canal economic zone, and we are providing all kinds of incentives.”

He said: “We are in the forefront in fighting terrorism... through holistic approach... and that’s why we managed to eradicate it in Egypt... And this is what I conveyed to our Indian friends.”



Interlocutor and former Dy NSA Pankaj Kumar Singh



the Gorkha community.”

Stating that the GJM was formed with the “sole aim” of securing the political identity and rights of the Gorkha community, the outfit leaders Bimal Gurung and Roshan Giri said: “We have dedicated nearly two decades of political activism for Gorkhaland state and granting of Scheduled Tribe status for the 11 Gorkha sub-tribes... A permanent solution under the Constitution of India for our region is not only vital for protecting the rights of the Gorkha community, but also essential for the overall progress and prosperity of the entire region and the people who live here. The Gorkha, Rajbongshi,

Adivasi, Bengali, and other communities have coexisted here in harmony for generations.”

Urging other political parties and social organisations from the region to welcome the “positive development”, the GJM said: “At this critical juncture, our foremost duty is to rise above individual interests and work together with a common agenda for the betterment of our people and our region. We call on everyone, regardless of their political or social affiliations, to join hands in unity, so that we can present a strong and collective voice.”

In a statement, Gorkha National Liberation Front (GNLF) chief Mann Ghising thanked PM

Modi and Shah, and said: “With this initiative, not just a few individuals or groups, but all concerned stakeholders will now have the opportunity to present their views, suggestions, and perspectives in a constructive manner... We firmly believe that this inclusive and consultative process will pave the way for a concrete, just, and permanent solution to the long-standing political aspirations of the Gorkha community.”

The BJP MP from Darjeeling, Raju Bista, expressed hope that all stakeholders, including the West Bengal government, would engage with the interlocutor “positively”.

the former director general of the BSF as the interlocutor, the ruling Trinamool Congress (TMC) dubbed it as another attempt by the BJP to woo Gorkha votes before next year’s Assembly polls.

“It is clear that this is another attempt to woo the voters of Darjeeling and the surrounding areas before the Assembly elections in the state,” Minister for North Bengal Development Udayan Guha told *The Indian Express* over the phone.

The Gorkha Janmukti Morcha (GJM), in a statement, said, “We thank Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Amit Shah for taking this posi-

RAVIK BHATTACHARYA KOLKATA, OCTOBER 17

THE CENTRE’S appointment of former Deputy National Security Adviser Pankaj Kumar Singh on Thursday as an interlocutor for talks with leaders of the Darjeeling hills in West Bengal over various demands from the region, including finding a “permanent political solution”, is once again poised to raise the issue of Gorkhaland statehood and the Scheduled Tribe status for 11 Gorkha sub-tribes.

While the Gorkha leaders from the region have welcomed the Centre’s decision to appoint





LCA Tejas Mk1A takes off for its maiden flight in Nashik Friday. ANI

LCA Tejas Mk1A takes first flight; symbol of self-reliance: Rajnath

AMRITA NAYAK DUTTA
NASHIK, OCTOBER 17

THE INDIGENOUS Light Combat Aircraft (LCA) Tejas Mk1A undertook its first public sortie at the Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL) facility in Nashik on Friday, a move that Defence Minister Rajnath Singh called a “shining symbol” of India’s growing self-reliance in defence. The event also marked the formal inauguration of the third production line of the LCA Mk1A and the second production line of the indigenously made Hindustan Turbo Trainer (HTT)-40 basic trainer aircraft.

In his address, Singh said India once imported 65-70 per cent of critical military hardware, but is now manufacturing 65 per cent of the equipment on its own soil, highlighting the government’s resolve to increase domestic manufacturing to 100 per cent in the years to come.

“We not only reduced import dependency, but also strengthened our commitment to indigenisation. Whatever we used to buy from abroad, we are now

EXPLAINED

Big boost to IAF

THE INAUGURAL flight of LCA Mk1A is a step towards formal induction into the IAF, which has been facing a decline in its fighter squadron strength. The newly inaugurated production line in Nashik has the capacity to manufacture 8 aircraft per year, and can be increased to 10. HAL is expected to produce 24 aircraft annually.

manufacturing it domestically, be it fighter aircraft, missiles, engines and electronic warfare systems,” he said. “We have now set a target of increasing defence manufacturing to Rs 3 lakh crore and exports to Rs 50,000 crore by 2029.”

An aerial display by the LCA Tejas Mk1A, an HTT-40 and Sukhoi-30 MKI was carried out at the ceremony. HAL Chief Test



Union Defence Minister Rajnath Singh during the Nashik event on Friday. PTI

Pilot (fixed wing) Group Capt K K Venugopal (retd) piloted the LCA Tejas Mk1A sortie after the aircraft got a water cannon salute.

In his address, Singh highlighted the need to stay ahead of the curve as Artificial Intelligence, cyber warfare, drone systems and next-generation aircraft are shaping the future, and wars are being fought across multiple frontiers. “India must always stay ahead in this new race, and not lag,” he said, exhorting HAL to make its mark in the fields of next-generation aircraft, unmanned systems and civil aviation, and not limit itself to LCA Tejas or HTT-40.

During Operation Sindoor, Indian forces not only demonstrated valour and commitment but also displayed confidence in indigenous platforms, he said.

“HAL provided support at various operational sites 24 hours a day during the operation. It ensured the IAF’s operational readiness by carrying out prompt maintenance on fighter jets and helicopters,” he said.

Sanjeev Kumar, Secretary, Defence Production, described the inauguration of two production lines as a symbol of India’s growing technological confidence, industrial strength, and strategic foresight. He said the LCA Tejas Mk1A is not merely a fighter aircraft but a statement of India’s design and manufacturing excellence—conceived, developed and produced indigenously through the collaboration of HAL, Aeronautical Development Agency, DRDO and the IAF.

D K Sunil, HAL Chairman and Managing Director, said the successful operationalisation of the LCA Mk1A and HTT-40 production from Nashik is a testament to HAL’s capacity for expansion.

SC flags rise in digital arrest scams, seeks CBI, Centre response

ANANTHAKRISHNANG
NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 17

TAKING NOTE of the rising instances of people being defrauded through “digital arrests”, the Supreme Court on Friday sought the response of the Union Ministry of Home Affairs and the CBI in the matter.

A Bench of Justices Surya Kant and Joymalya Bagchi was hearing a complaint by a senior citizen couple from Ambala who said they were defrauded of over Rs 1.05 crore by digital arrest fraudsters who threatened them with forged orders of the Supreme Court, the Bombay High Court, and the Enforcement Directorate. The Supreme Court had taken suo motu cognizance of their September 21 complaint.

Hearing it, the Bench said, “We are also inclined to take judicial notice that the instant case is not the solitary instance. It has been largely reported many a times in the media that such like instances have taken place in different parts of the country. We are therefore prima facie of the view that stern action on a pan-India basis with coordinated efforts between central and state police are required to unearth the full extent of this criminal enterprise involving forgery of judicial documents and extortion/robbery and arrests of innocent people, especially senior citizens.”

The couple said in their complaint that they were contacted by persons impersonating CBI and IB officers, and judicial authorities through telephone and video calls.

The fraudsters displayed forged orders of the top court through WhatsApp and video conferencing, threatening arrest and property seizure, and coerced the couple into transferring money through multiple transactions between

September 3 and 16.

Two FIRs were registered at the Cyber Crime Branch, Ambala, in this connection.

The court said, “Ordinarily we would have directed the state police to expedite the investigation and take the case to its logical conclusion. We are, however, aghast by the fact that the fraudsters have fabricated multiple judicial orders in the name of the Supreme Court, including a freeze order dated September 3 purportedly issued under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act, an arrest order dated September 3 bearing the stamp and designation of an officer of ED, Mumbai, along with a court stamp, a surveillance order with forged judicial signatures, and various fictitious proceedings before the Mumbai High Court and false claims of investigation by CBI and ED.”

It said, “the forgery of documents and the brazen criminal misuse of the name, seal, and judicial authority of this Court or High Court is a matter of grave concern”.

“The fabrication of judicial orders bearing forged signatures of the judges strikes at the very foundation of public trust in the judicial system besides the rule of law. Such action constitutes a direct assault on the dignity and majesty of the institution. Therefore, such grave criminal acts cannot be treated as an ordinary or routine offence of cheating or cyber-crime,” the court said. The Bench also issued notice to the Principal Secretary, Home Department of Haryana, and the Superintendent of Police, Cyber Crime, Ambala, and sought a report on the status of the investigation from the latter.

Having regard to the nature of the crimes, the court also requested the assistance of Attorney General R Venkataramani in the matter.

The court will hear the matter next on October 27.

Apex court forms panel to recommend equal opportunity policy for transgender persons

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 17

THE SUPREME Court Friday set up a committee under former Delhi High Court judge Justice Asha Menon to recommend a viable equal opportunity policy for transgender persons in the areas of employment and education. A two-judge bench of Justices J B Pardiwala and R Mahadevan constituted the committee while deciding the plea of a trans woman teacher, who alleged that her services were unlawfully terminated by a school in Uttar Pradesh and another in Gujarat over her gender identity. The SC ordered compensation for the petitioner, to be paid Rs 50,000 each by the states of UP and Gujarat, the Centre, and the second school (in Gujarat) that denied her job.

The court, however, disagreed with petitioner Jane Kaushik's allegations against the UP school, saying that perusal of the communications indicates the... school "accommodated her requests from the beginning and attempted to make her stay and school environment as conducive for her as possible". The SC pointed out an inquiry by the National Commission for Women "came to the conclusion the first school's conduct was not discriminatory against the petitioner". The panel will comprise Sanjay Sharma, retired chief executive officer of Association for Transgender Health in India; Akkai Padmashali, a Karnataka-based trans rights activist; Grace Banu, a Dalit rights and trans rights activist; Vyjayanthi Vasanta Mogli, a Telangana-based trans rights activist; Gaurav Mandal,

Associate Professor at Jindal Global University; Nithya Rajshekhar, Senior Associate at Centre for Law & Policy, Bengaluru; and Senior Advocate Jayna Kothari as amicus curiae. It will have Secretaries of the Department of Social Justice & Empowerment, of Ministries of Women and Child Development, Health and Family Welfare, Education, of Labour and Employment, Department of Personnel and Training, Secretary, Department of Legal Affairs, as ex-officio members. The SC asked the panel to submit its draft report in six months and directed the Union to consider the recommendations and come up with its own draft "preferably within a further period of three months from the date on which the report is submitted by the advisory committee to this court".

The committee will also highlight lacunae in the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019, and the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Rules, 2020, and suggest adequate measures to best address them. Deciding the case, the SC noted that there is no effective implementation of the 2019 Act and 2020 Rules. "Unfortunately, it appears that the 2019 Act and the 2020 Rules respectively have been brutishly reduced to dead letters. The Union of India and the States have exhibited a grossly apathetic attitude towards the transgender community, by defacing the lived realities of this community with their inaction. Considering the protraction of this inaction, such an attitude cannot be reasonably considered to be inadvertent or accidental; it appears intentional and seems to stem from deep-

rooted societal stigma and the lack of bureaucratic will to effectuate the provisions..." it said. The ruling noted except Bengal, Tamil Nadu, and Delhi, "no other State has brought forth any rules along the lines of the 2020 Rules. Orissa and Kerala respectively are the only States that have undertaken comprehensive policy measures. The other States have situated themselves in a comfortable silence." The court said "the 2019 Act, is dotted with shortcomings and pitfalls" and "the glaring reality remains that, as a statute, it plainly recognises the rights of transgender persons without creating any mechanisms for how the rights can be materialised. These shortcomings are an instance of omisive discrimination and in teeth of the principle of substantive equality provided in the Constitution".

‘Govt mulls easing curbs on certain Chinese imports’

REUTERS
NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 17

THE MINISTRY of Commerce and Industry and government think-tank NITI Aayog are pushing to ease certain tariff and non-tariff curbs on Chinese imports, three officials said, acknowledging the country's growing reliance on Chinese raw materials.

They are seeking measures including allowing anti-dumping duties to lapse on certain products, while considering tariff cuts on raw materials used in sectors such as leather and engineering goods where domestic capacity remains limited, the sources said.

“A consensus is emerging within the government and the industry that, while negotiating a deal with Washington, India needs to fine-tune its trade policy, including trade relations with China,” one of the government officials said.

Both the commerce ministry and the NITI Aayog have backed industry calls to cut import tariffs on raw materials at inter-ministerial meetings, a second official said, noting countries such as Vietnam import Chinese raw ma-



File

India is also considering easing Chinese investment curbs on a case-by-case basis.

terials at zero duty, putting Indian manufacturers at a disadvantage.

However, the final decision on duty cuts rests with the finance ministry, the official said. The sources spoke on condition of anonymity as details are not public. India's commerce ministry didn't immediately respond to an email seeking comment.

The government would also not renew anti-dumping duties on items such as axle beams, steering components and high-tenacity polyester yarn, another government source said. However, India's trade remedies authority has launched new anti-dumping probes on certain imports from China on local complaints.

WTO chief to US, China: De-escalate trade war, or risk long-term impact on global GDP growth

REUTERS
WASHINGTON, OCTOBER 17

THE HEAD of the World Trade Organization said she is urging the US and China to de-escalate trade tensions, warning that a decoupling by the world's two largest economies could reduce global economic output by 7 per cent over the longer term.

WTO Director-General Ngozi Okonjo-Iweala told *Reuters* in an interview the global trade body was extremely concerned about the latest spike in US-China trade tensions and had spoken with officials from both countries to encourage more dialogue.

“We're obviously worried at any escalation of US-China tensions,” she said, noting the two sides had backed away from their

first tariff escalation earlier this year, averting more serious consequences and she hoped that would happen again. “Similarly, we are really hoping that the two sides will come together and they will de-escalate, because any US-China tensions and... decoupling (would) have implications not just for the two biggest economies in the world, but also for the rest of the world,” she said.

Both sides, Okonjo-Iweala said, understand the importance of good relations, given the implications for the global economy and other countries. Any kind of decoupling that divides the world into two trading blocs would result in “significant global GDP losses in the longer term — up to 7 per cent global GDP losses and double-digit welfare losses for developing countries,” she said.

‘Govt working on steps to improve supply of rare earth minerals’

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 17

THE GOVERNMENT is working on measures to improve supply of rare earth minerals, including negotiating trade pacts with Chile and Peru, promoting domestic exploration, and engaging startups in recycling and processing, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Friday.

Critical or rare earth minerals such as copper, lithium, nickel, and cobalt are essential raw materials which have applications in various industries ranging from electronic goods to fighter jets.

The Indian team is visiting the two South American countries for



ANI

the next round of trade talks.

“Look at Chile and Peru, think about it. Why am I doing FTA with them in the first place? It gives you the answer,” he said when asked about steps the government is taking to deal with the shortage of these minerals. China, the major player of these minerals, has imposed curbs on the supply, which is disrupting the supply chains worldwide.

YELLOW METAL'S SHARE IN TOTAL RESERVES ROSE TO 14.7%, HIGHEST SINCE 1996-97: TRADERS

RBI's gold pile tops \$100 bn on surging prices

REUTERS
MUMBAI, OCTOBER 17

INDIA'S GOLD reserves crossed the \$100 billion mark for the first time, according to the Reserve Bank of India's latest foreign exchange reserves data, buoyed by a global price rally even as the central bank's purchases slowed sharply this year.

India's gold holdings rose by \$3.595 billion to \$102.365 billion in the week through October 10, RBI data showed on Friday, while overall foreign exchange reserves declined \$2.18 billion to \$697.784 billion.

The share of gold in India's total reserves climbed to 14.7 per cent, the highest since 1996-97, ac-



File

ording to traders.

Gold's share in India's foreign exchange reserves has almost

doubled over the past decade — from below 7 per cent to nearly 15 per cent — reflecting both

steady central bank accumulation and a surge in global bullion prices.

That's led to the \$100 billion milestone being hit despite a marked slowdown in the RBI's gold purchases this year.

The central bank bought gold in only four of the first nine months of 2025, compared with near-monthly additions in 2024, according to World Gold Council data.

Cumulative buying from January to September stood at just 4 tonnes, sharply lower than 50 tonnes in the same period a year earlier.

The share of gold in India's foreign exchange reserves has increased significantly, largely driven by valuation gains from

the rising gold price, said Kavita Chacko, research head for India at the World Gold Council.

Gold has surged about 65 per cent in 2025, powered by a potent mix of macroeconomic, institutional and psychological drivers.

Global central banks continue to accumulate gold as part of reserve diversification away from the US dollar — a trend spurred by heightened geopolitical risks, sanctions pressures and de-dollarisation.

India is the world's second-largest consumer of gold and relies on imports to meet demand. Buying gold is deeply rooted in Indian culture, driven by tradition and its role as both an investment and a status symbol.

WE CAN'T DEplete OUR COUNTRY: U.S. PRESIDENT, DAY AFTER PUTIN CALL

Trump meets Zelenskyy, signals not sure of selling long-range missiles

Ukraine leader: Trump has big chance to end war

ASSOCIATED PRESS & REUTERS
WASHINGTON, OCT 17

PRESIDENT DONALD Trump is hosting Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy for talks at the White House on Friday, with the US leader signalling he's not ready to agree to sell Kyiv a long-range missile system that Ukraine says they desperately need.

Zelenskyy arrived with top aides to discuss the latest developments with Trump over lunch, a day after the US president and Russian President Vladimir Putin held a lengthy phone call to discuss the conflict.

At the start of the talks, Zelenskyy congratulated Trump over landing last week's cease-fire and hostage deal in Gaza and said Trump now has "momentum" to stop the Russia-Ukraine conflict. "President Trump now has a big chance to finish this war," Zelenskyy added.

In recent days, Trump had shown an openness to selling Ukraine long-range Tomahawk cruise missiles, even as Putin



President Donald Trump with Ukraine's Volodymyr Zelenskyy at the White House, Friday. AP

warned that such a move would further strain the US-Russian relationship. But following Thursday's call with Putin, Trump appeared to downplay the prospects of Ukraine getting the missiles.

"We need Tomahawks for the United States of America too," Trump said. "We have a lot of them, but we need them. I mean we can't deplete our country." Zelenskyy had been seeking the

weapons, which would allow Ukrainian forces to strike deep into Russian territory and target key military sites, energy facilities and critical infrastructure.

But Putin warned Trump during the call that supplying Kyiv with the Tomahawks "won't change the situation on the battlefield, but would cause substantial damage to the relationship between our countries," according to Yuri Ushakov,

Putin's foreign policy adviser. Zelenskyy is expected to offer to store American liquefied natural gas in Ukraine's gas storage facilities, which would allow for an American presence in the European energy market.

Trump announced following Thursday's call with Putin that he would soon meet with the Russian leader in Budapest, Hungary, to discuss ways to end the war.

EXPLAINED

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Putin counters Kyiv tactics

UKRAINE'S PREFERRED strategy in the war is to obtain more weapons deliveries to strike deeper inside Russia, and forcing it to negotiate in earnest. But analysts say that Vladimir Putin, in his call with Trump on Thursday, effectively countered that strategy with the prospect of more talks and a peace deal. He achieved a path that is appealing to Trump — who is looking forward to his “ninth deal” — and buys him time to strengthen the offensive.

Kremlin envoy suggests 'Putin-Trump tunnel'

Russia and the United States should build a "Putin-Trump" rail tunnel under the Bering Strait to link their countries, unlock joint exploration of natural resources and "symbolise unity", a Kremlin envoy has suggested. The proposal by Kirill Dmitriev, Putin's investment envoy, envisages a project costing \$8 billion.

Unlawful move: US business body sues govt's H1-B fee hike

SHUBHAJIT ROY
NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 17

A MONTH after US President Donald Trump announced a sweeping overhaul of the H-1B visa system that targets skilled Indians, the US chamber of Commerce has legally challenged the \$100,000 fee for H-1B visa petitions, calling it "unlawful".

Trump had, on September 19, signed an order that will raise the fee for these visas to \$100,000 (Rs 88 lakh) annually, making it prohibitively expensive for companies to hire foreign professionals in the US. A day later, the administration clarified that the new fee was a "one-time payment" applicable only to "new petitions and does not apply to current visa holders".

Currently, the H-1B visa fee ranges from about \$2000-\$5000 depending on employer size and other costs. The visas are valid for

three years and can be renewed for another three years. Companies pay to sponsor H1B applicants.

The lawsuit argues "the new fee is unlawful because it overrides provisions of the Immigration and Nationality Act that govern the H-1B program, including the requirement that fees be based on the costs incurred by the government..." Neil Bradley, Executive Vice President and Chief Policy Officer at the Chamber, said: "The new \$100,000 visa fee will make it cost-prohibitive for U.S. employers..."

Praising Trump for his border reforms, Bradley said: "With the border secure, we now have a once-in-a-generation opportunity to accomplish targeted legal immigration reforms... The president has said he wants to educate, attract, and retain the world's best and brightest in the U.S., and the Chamber shares that goal," he said.

Amid price surge, should you buy new or exchange old gold?

SIDDHARTH UPASANI
NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 17

SACHIN TENDULKAR is now battling for India's macroeconomic stability. In an advertisement for Tanishq, he explains why Indians should exchange their old gold for new jewels.

"India imports almost all its gold. But if you exchange your old gold (for new jewelry), there will be no need to import gold. This will make our country stronger," Tendulkar says.

He is right. Higher gold imports widen India's merchandise trade deficit, which means India has to pay more in foreign currencies than what it receives for its exports. A widening of this deficit weakens the Indian rupee, which makes foreign goods and services even more expensive. And gold is a big factor when it comes to these trade dynamics.

Indians love gold

India is second only to China in its thirst for gold. According to the World Gold Council

(WGC), Chinese consumers bought 857 tonnes (tn) of gold in 2024, and Indians 803 tn. Over the last 15 years, the two countries have consistently accounted for over half of the global consumer demand for the yellow metal.

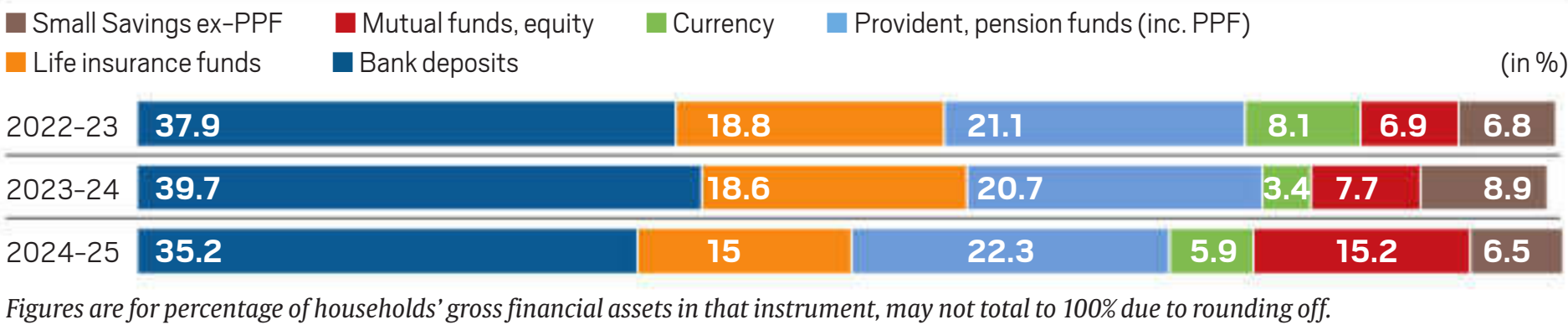
But this is just the annual demand for gold. According to Morgan Stanley economists Upasna Chachra and Bani Gambhir, Indian households owned 34,600 tn of gold as at the end of June this year. With prices at an all-time high, this gold is worth roughly \$3.8 trillion: or 89% of India's GDP.

"...the stock of holdings of gold provides a positive wealth effect to the household balance sheet, which is also benefiting from cyclical factors of lower interest payments with monetary policy easing, and the positive impact on disposable income through direct and indirect tax cuts," Chachra and Gambhir wrote last week.

Savings breakdown

Just over a decade ago, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) Governor Raghuram Rajan warned Indians of the perils of their love af-

CHANGING PATTERN OF HOUSEHOLDS' FINANCIAL SAVINGS



fair with gold. At the time, households were aggressively buying gold to stop their savings being eroded by rapidly rising prices.

WGC data show that Indians' consumption demand for gold is down nearly 20% from around 15 years ago. This is in part due to RBI having sharply brought down headline inflation, from almost 10% in 2012-13 to an expected 2.6% in the current fiscal.

Indians are also investing in different assets now. As per latest RBI data, the share of

households' mutual fund and equity investments doubled to 15.2% of their gross financial savings in 2024-25 on the back of an incredible shift to the stock market. According to data from the NSE, individuals put in Rs 1.66 lakh crore into Indian equities in 2024 on a net basis — more than the Rs 1.53 lakh crore they invested in the previous 10 years combined.

Data from the statistics ministry show that household savings in the form of physical assets reduced in the years leading up to the

Covid-19 pandemic to 36.9% of gross savings in 2020-21 from 45.9% in 2011-12. It then rose to 43.8% in 2022-23 — widely attributed to the purchase of homes and vehicles as people took advantage of low interest rates — before edging down again to 41.5% in 2023-24.

The trend for savings in the form of gold and silver ornaments is similar: from 1.1% of gross savings in 2011-12 to 0.7% in 2020-21, 0.8% in 2022-23, and back to 0.7% in 2023-24.

Behind Tendulkar's message

If Indians' demand for gold has reduced over the years, why did Tanishq employ Tendulkar to educate the public on why lowering gold imports is beneficial for the Indian economy? The answer: rising gold prices.

A host of factors — uncertainty caused by the US tariff war, its potential impact on economic growth and inflation, geopolitical risks and purchases by central banks around the world — have led to the price of gold rising more rapidly than analysts expected. It crossed the Rs 1-lakh-per-10-gram mark earlier this year in April; it is now moving towards Rs 1.3 lakh, up more than 50% from last year.

This surge has hit the ability of Indians to buy gold, which is hurting jewelers, making the exchange of old gold for new jewellery an attractive business proposal.

The impact of the higher prices is showing up in India's trade data. Data released Wednesday show that gold imports were down 9% for the first half of 2025-26. But with Diwali around the corner, September saw gold imports jump to \$9.62 billion — double that from a year ago.

GDP: GRAPHS, DATA, PERSPECTIVES

Why European firms lost their competitiveness

UDIT MISRA
NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 17

DURING A curtain raiser for the latest World Economic Outlook by the International Monetary Fund (IMF), Managing Director Kristalina Georgieva shared remarkable data about Europe's economy. The *table* (bottom five) shows companies in the European Union that are less than 50 years old, but now have a market capitalisation of more than \$10 billion. They are dwarfed when compared to similar firms in the United States (top five), Georgieva said. "...my beloved, native Europe, some tough love: enough lofty rhetoric on how to lift competitiveness — you know what must be done. It is time for action."

How did Europe, which basically ran the world until a century ago and was the birthplace of the Enlightenment and Industrial Revolution, get here?

The newly minted Nobel laureate in Economics, Philippe Aghion, recently commented on this issue. He said that while Europe was catching up with US standards of living as it recovered after the devastation of World War II, since the mid-1980s, the average per capita GDP (read income) of the Eurozone has declined relative to the US. "The big reason is that we failed to implement breakthrough high-tech innovations".

Aghion said that at the heart of the matter was Europe's inability to reconcile competition policy (which aims to promote fair competition in an economy by clamping down on anti-competitive entities such as monopolies) and industrial policy (which aims to promote national industries). "In Europe, in the name of competition policy, we became very anti any form of industrial policy," he said.

While he was quick to point out that he does not welcome the "protection-

US FIRMS DOMINATE

Name	Marketcap (in \$ billion)
NVIDIA	4378.3
Microsoft	3816.4
Apple	3700.3
Alphabet (Google)	3039.6
Amazon	2299
Spotify	138.1
Adyen	53.9
DSV	49.5
EQT	41.2
Amadeus IT Group	34.1

Note: Select companies that came up in the past 50 years and a market cap of more than \$10 billion. Source: Companiesmarketcap.com

ist wave" in the US as it is not good for global growth and innovation, he could see the bright side: "European countries have to realise that we should no longer let the US and China become the technological leaders and lose to them."

Georgieva's solution? A "single market czar" with real authority to drive reforms forward for the bloc. She argued for an energy union, removing border frictions in the labour market, goods and services trade, energy, and finance, and building a single European financial system. Ultimately, Europe has to "Catch up with the private sector dynamism of the US," she said.

Note the number of Indian companies that figure in the list of top 100 global companies in terms of market capitalisation. The US has 59, China 12, Europe and the rest of the world have 27 companies. India has two — Reliance at number 71 and HDFC Bank at 90.

ANJALI MARAR & AMITABH SINHA
BENGALURU, NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 17

THE ATMOSPHERIC concentration of carbon dioxide (CO₂), the primary driver of climate change, increased by a record amount between 2023 and 2024, according to latest data released by the World Meteorological Organization (WMO). Globally averaged CO₂ concentration near the Earth's surface reached 423.9 parts per million in 2024, 3.5 ppm higher than in 2023. The year-on-year increase in this period was significantly higher than the annual average during the 2011-2020 decade.

The year 2024 was also the warmest year ever recorded, with the global average temperature being 1.55 degrees Celsius higher than pre-industrial times. This was the first time that global annual temperatures had crossed the 1.5 degree Celsius threshold, a key limit which, when breached over a long-term period, can result in devastating irreversible impacts.

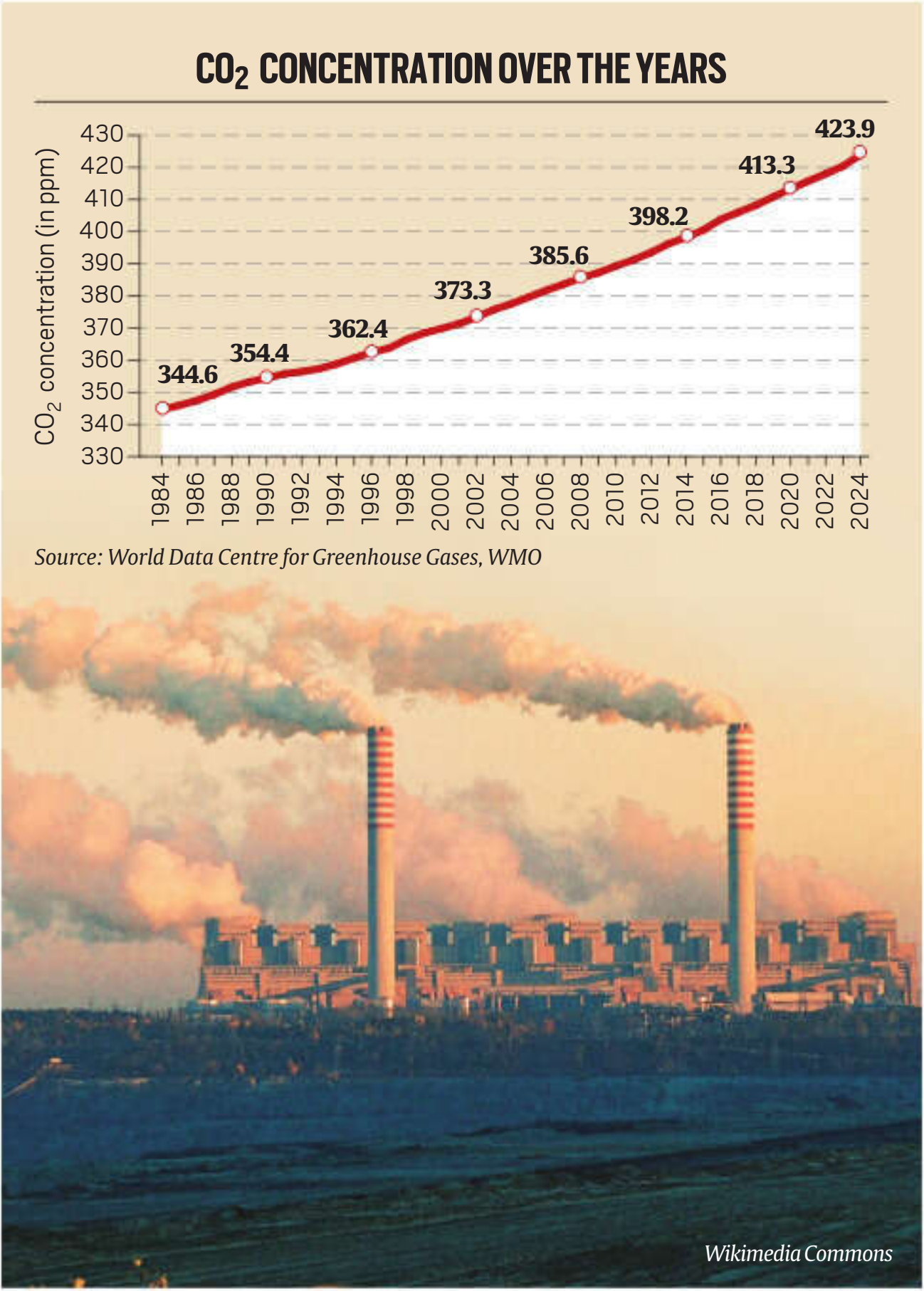
The rapidly rising CO₂ concentrations underscore the failure of the international climate framework, as represented by the Paris Agreement, to achieve a meaningful slowdown in global emissions.

Rise in CO₂ concentrations

CO₂ concentrations have been rising consistently over the years. There has been no instance of a decline in the last 40 years, at least. However, the new data from the WMO show that the year-on-year increase between 2023 and 2024 was the highest since these kinds of measurements began in 1957. This has come at a time when a massive effort is being made globally to restrain CO₂ emissions.

The rate of increase in CO₂ concentrations had already tripled from an average of 0.8 ppm per year during the 1960s to 2.4 ppm per year between 2011 and 2020. But a 3.5 ppm jump in a year is unprecedented. The current CO₂ concentration in the atmosphere, 423.9 ppm, is now 152% more than the pre-industrial levels of 278.3 ppm.

CO₂ is the most widespread of the greenhouse gases (GHGs), and is produced in a variety of natural and man-made processes. The emissions from natural processes such as respiration, ocean releases, volcano eruptions, wildfires, or decomposition of organic matter are nearly all absorbed back in other natural processes like photosynthesis, ocean and land sinks, thus maintaining a balance. Nearly half of the CO₂ emissions from man-made processes, such as the burning of fossil fuels,



is also absorbed by these natural sinks. It is the other half that accumulates in the atmosphere, resulting in a warming effect.

Although CO₂ accounts for more than 90% of all accumulated GHGs in the atmosphere, its ability to trap heat is significantly less than other GHGs such as methane (CH₄) and nitrous oxide (N₂O). CH₄ is at least 25% more potent than CO₂ in its heat-trapping capability, while N₂O is about 270 times more potent.

However, CO₂ remains in the atmosphere for a far longer time, about hundreds to thousands of years. As a result, it has a cumulative

impact on global warming. CO₂ is known to have contributed about 66% of the warming that has happened since pre-industrial times, and about 79% in the last decade.

In comparison, CH₄ is relatively short-lived and remains in the atmosphere for only about 12 to 14 years. N₂O disintegrates after about 100 to 120 years.

Reasons behind the increase

The unusually high increase of 3.5 ppm between 2023 and 2024 could not be solely attributed to continued emissions of CO₂ from man-made activities, the WMO report

said. Variabilities in the natural CO₂ loop also had a role to play.

In particular, oceans and land sinks seem to have absorbed a lesser amount of CO₂ in 2024. An exceptionally high number of forest fire incidents in the year resulted in additional emissions.

One of the causes of the reduced capability of natural sinks in oceans and land to absorb CO₂ is global warming itself. At higher temperatures, oceans absorb less CO₂ due to decreased solubility. Similarly, extreme droughts, which result in forests and vegetation drying up, reduce the absorption capacity of trees and grasslands. These processes feed into each other and worsen the CO₂ imbalance, leading to more CO₂ being released into the atmosphere.

Other GHGs

The concentration of CH₄ and N₂O also increased in 2024, but the jump was lower than the annual average witnessed in the last decade. CH₄ — the second most widely emitted GHG — concentrations increased by 8 parts per billion to reach a level of 1,942 ppb in the atmosphere, while N₂O concentrations increased by 1 ppb to reach 338 ppb.

In the last decade, CH₄ concentrations increased by an average of about 10.6 ppb every year, while N₂O concentrations increased at the rate of 1.07 ppb a year.

CH₄ concentrations account for 16% of the warming caused since pre-industrial times, while N₂O concentrations contributed about 6%. The rest come from other gases and processes.

Challenges

The new data from the WMO Greenhouse Gas Bulletin underline the enormity of the challenge being faced in restraining the rapid accumulation of GHGs in the atmosphere. It is not just the man-made activities, over which humans have some control, that are accentuating the problem. Natural processes are also getting destabilised under the influence of global warming, resulting in greater accumulation of these gases.

However, even in areas where they have some control, humans have been finding it extremely difficult to rein in emissions of GHGs. Global emissions are still on the rise. Ten years of the Paris Agreement have been unable to make any appreciable dent in this rising trend. The emission reduction targets for 2030 are almost certain to be missed, while global temperatures already breached the 1.5 degree Celsius mark in 2024.

Muttaqi's Deoband visit: driven by personal connection & religious diplomacy

SHUBHAJIT ROY, ASAD REHMAN & PRAGNYESH
NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 17

AFGHANISTAN FOREIGN Minister Amir Khan Muttaqi's visit to the Darul Uloom seminary in Deoband, Uttar Pradesh last week can be seen from the prism of "religious diplomacy". Sources said that New Delhi facilitated the visit upon receiving a "request" from the Taliban leader who left India on Thursday after an unprecedented eight-day trip.

A historic madrasa

Located around 150 km from Delhi in Deoband, a small town in the Saharanpur district, Darul Uloom was established in 1866 as an Islamic alternative to British-run universities of the time.

The seminary gave birth to the influen-

tial Deobandi movement, a Sunni revalist movement that sought to resist Western cultural and religious influences on Islam in South Asia during colonial rule. 'Deobandism' is known for its 'orthopraxy', adherence to the rationalist Hanafi school of jurisprudence, and an emphasis on piety and morality.

Within only a few years of its establishment, the influence of the Deoband madrasa spread far and wide. For more than a century, the seminary has been an "incomparable teaching institution for the religious education of the Muslims not only in the sub-continent but also throughout the Islamic world", said one official at the madrasa.

The seminary is credited for creating political consciousness among Muslims in the subcontinent, and also taking part in the freedom struggle against the British. Today, the Darul Uloom is among the most

renowned religious and academic centres in the Islamic world, considered second to only the Al-Azhar University in Cairo.

Taliban connection

After 1947, Maulana Abdul Haq, a teacher at the Deoband seminary, established the Darul Uloom Haqqania near Peshawar in what was then the North West Frontier Province of Pakistan. This seminary, modelled around the one in Deoband and preaching the same brand of Sunni Islam, would go on to become the birthplace of the Taliban.

After the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan in 1979, Darul Uloom Haqqania essentially became a training ground for Afghan resistance fighters. Sami ul Haq, the son of Abdul Haq who had taken over the seminary by then, essentially took the idea of a personal struggle (*jihad*) and modified it with a fo-

cus on fighting the Soviets in Afghanistan.

Some of these resistance fighters, including Mullah Omar, Taliban's founding leader, and Jalaluddin Haqqani, who established the group's military wing, would later form the Taliban (literally "students" in Pashto).

Born in Afghanistan's Helmand Province in 1970, Muttaqi emigrated to neighbouring Pakistan after the Soviet invasion. He too would study at the Darul Uloom Haqqania. For Muttaqi, visiting the Darul Uloom Deoband was thus of "personal" significance, although officials at the seminary say that the school in UP has consistently distanced itself from the actions of the Taliban.

Diplomatic significance

From a diplomatic perspective, New Delhi's decision to allow Muttaqi to travel

to Deoband is significant amid its own engagement with the Taliban regime in Kabul, and the nosedive in Pakistan-Afghanistan ties. New Delhi, watching the growing wedge between its western neighbours, has sought to establish the influence of Indian institutions over Islam in South Asia.

There is a message here for the Taliban, too. While Darul Uloom Deoband has insisted on gender-segregation in education, it has historically issued fatwas supporting girls' right to learn, in contrast to the actions and ideology of the Taliban.

This is not the first time that India has employed "religious diplomacy" while engaging with leaders from Islamic countries. One notable example was former Iran President Akbar Hashemi Rafsanjani's visit to Lucknow in April 1995.

In Lucknow, a city with a large Shiite population, Rafsanjani addressed a crowd of over 10,000 at the Bara Imambara. In his

speech, he notably endorsed Indian secularism and stated that Indian Muslims should feel safe in the country. This was particularly important as this visit came just a few years after the 1992 demolition of the Babri Masjid, an event that had strained India's relations with many Muslim-majority nations.

At the Deoband seminary, Muttaqi was greeted by a crowd of nearly 15,000 students who turned up to catch a glimpse of the leader. He delivered a 30-minute speech to a 4,000-strong crowd of students, scholars, and clerics, and had private conversations with many dignitaries.

Shah Alam, 22, a student at a nearby madrasa, was one of the many thousand who arrived at the Darul Uloom campus to see Muttaqi. He said: "Humare liye toh wo Deoband ko maante hai, utna hi kaafi hai (For us, it's enough that he believes in Deoband)."